

Leeds Festival a few weeks after *Fantasia*. It is a large-scale, four-movement choral setting of words by the US poet Walt Whitman, whose soaring yet spiritually agnostic imaginative world was a powerful liberating influence on Vaughan Williams's generation. The composer's mastery of his choral and orchestral forces began a lifelong sequence of nine symphonies, which lie at the core of an enormous musical output.

The essence of Vaughan Williams's musical world is crystallized in *The Lark Ascending*, based on a poem by George Meredith; this describes how the flying bird's song seems to float skyward, until it drifts beyond hearing. The music was composed for violin and piano in 1914, before the composer's service in World War I, then orchestrated before the first performance in 1920. The result was another understated musical revolution. The virtuosity of the solo violin part, different from spectacular 19th-century tradition, related back to the purity of line found in the concertos of Bach. Neither of the work's two main themes is actually a folk song, but each sounds as if it might be; and neither could have been written without the example of English folk music itself.

Army service in World War I then halted Vaughan Williams's composing for several years. His first major work afterward was *A Pastoral Symphony*, whose slow second movement features a solo trumpet imitating an army bugle, as if heard across a wide landscape in a quiet moment between relentless shellfire; and the finale is framed at its beginning and end by a solo soprano voice singing wordlessly, as if from a peaceful world that has managed to survive. Yet there were also unexpected stages in Vaughan